

huge way in India. Gaming has always been informal with LAN parties in the neighbourhood cyber café the extent to which it could be called an organised activity.

However in recent years, as computer penetration increased and broadband connections became more and more widely available, corporates started venturing into organising game events. One of them was Games2Win which organised a team of gamers called Temple of Seven and sent them for international tournaments like the World Cyber Games. However the experiment didn't last long and it was discontinued.

When we asked Alok Kejriwal, CEO of Games2Win what he thought about the gaming scene in India he was quite downbeat. He said that the T-7 experiment's failure has proved that as of now gaming is not sustainable in India.

"Gaming has a long way to go in India before it attains the reach and popularity levels in the advanced countries. In fact I think that gaming as seen in those countries will never catch on in India."

Why? "There are many reasons for this. Apart from the fact that computer and Internet penetration is low in India playing the cutting edge games require plenty of cutting edge hardware mainly in terms of processors and graphic cards which are costly. But the more basic issue is entertainment. Indians have so many avenues to keep themselves entertained, from Bollywood to cricket that they don't really need games to do the job. Indian parents are also not very receptive to games, considering them to be a waste of time and unhealthy."

While all these are valid and commonly cited reasons one thing which Kejriwal mentioned about the reason games won't ever be a phenomenon in India is the weather. His take is that weather in India is generally pleasant and indoor activities like gaming won't ever be favoured over going out and having fun. While this is certainly interesting, serious studies need to be conducted to back up this claim.

So is the situation hopeless? "Not really. We need content that can excite Indian gamers. We need a game that does for gaming what *Ramayana* did for television. Besides, we need better infrastructure and good competition. We are optimistic that the situation will improve in the next five years," says Kejriwal.

Lack of competition is one of the biggest things that hamper Indian gamers from taking on the best of the world. To be great at any game players need to match their wits against human players, not computer bots. And those players need to be equally good, or even better. The same scenario is prevalent in any real world sport too: the quality of your game is as good as that of your



The Indian weather is too nice for people to be content with sitting in their houses when they could be out having fun

Alok Kejriwal
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competition. Indian gamers are unable to get on international game servers mainly because of Indian IPs being banned or because of slow broadband connections that have high ping times. So when Indian gamers go for international tournaments, they come back defeated.

Corporate Games

In spite of all the above mentioned hurdles, gaming in India has slowly but steadily changed from purely a hobby to a means to make some decent pocket money. These days there is a gaming expo or a tournament organised every other week in the metros and sometimes even in the bigger cities. Gaming clans are flourishing and the members spend nights fragging each other in *Counter Strike* or racing against each other in *NFS*.

Some big names like Reliance World and Sify actively promote gaming events where prizes worth lakhs are at stake. Reliance World has its Gamebox National Championships where the total prize money at stake is about Rs 10 lakh. According to Rishikant Nimbark, Product Manager—Gaming, Reliance World is embarking on a few steps to create the necessary infrastructure for gaming. This includes establishing a gaming zone in the network of Reliance World retail outlets spread out across India. Reliance World appears to be gung-ho about the gaming prospects in India and is confident that within a few years with enough exposure Indian gamers would be world beaters.

Another company that is maintaining a positive attitude on the Indian gaming scene is Rapture Gaming. This Singapore-based company organises gaming events like WCG Singapore, E Sports Championships and the Compaq AMD pro gaming league. Rapture Gaming is interested in the Indian pro gaming scenario and this is what Herman Ng, MD of the company has to say, "Indian gamers have a lot of passion and that is really a key to success but in terms of experience and exposure, this is the area where they lose out to the other countries."

Conclusion

For most of us gaming will always remain a hobby. But like many other hobbies today if you are really good at what you do, gaming can get you decent pocket money and also a bit of fame. But if you are one of the best you can earn pots of money and get mobbed in game conventions the world over. You also get the chance to go see exotic places, stay in plush hotels and maybe get yourself featured in magazines and newspapers.

Five years down the line, gaming in India will change for the better. For now, gamers are advised not to burn their bridges and concentrate only on gaming—there always needs to be a plan B. ☒

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